DOMNA BANAKOU

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About Me

- Researcher with strong academic research background in the fields of virtual reality, cognitive neuroscience, and psychology.
- Combining technical expertise and experience in research methodologies for the design and implementation of virtual reality applications, experimental studies, data collection and analysis.
- Solid teamwork and leadership skills including organization and management of academic conferences and projects.
- Experience with cross-functional teams.

Education

PhD in Clinical Psychology and Psychobiology

University of Barcelona, Spain *(2014 – 2017)*
Funded by the FI-DGR 2014 Grant for universities and research centres for the recruitment of new research personnel.
Website: https://web.ub.edu/en/ | Level in EQF: EQF level 8

MSc in Computer Graphics, Vision and Imaging

University College London, United Kingdom *(2009 – 2010)*
Website: https://www.ucl.ac.uk/ | Level in EQF: EQF level 7

BSc in Computer Science

Ionian University, Greece *(2004 – 2009)*
Website: https://di.ionio.gr/en/ | Level in EQF: EQF level 6

Academic Appointments & Research Positions

Visiting Assistant Professor of Interactive Media, Arts & Humanities Division

New York University (NYU) Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates (August 2022 – August 2025)

- *Led independent and collaborative research projects in the field of virtual reality and cognitive neuroscience within NYU and internationally.*
- *Developed and taught core, elective, and capstone courses.*
- *Supervised and mentored undergraduate and graduate students, PhD students, and junior faculty.*
- *Served on various departmental and university committees related to research and academic affairs.*
- *Co-established and Managed the XR Lab at the department of Interactive Media.*
- *Assisted setting up the VR Lab at Social Roles and Beliefs Lab (led by Dr. Andrea Vial) at the department of Psychology.*
- *Secured funding from Tamkeen (76 71220 ADHPG VP211) to support the project's development and data collection.*
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Assistant Professor of Design, Creation & Multimedia

Universitat Oberta de Catalunya, Barcelona, Spain (March 2021 – June 2022)

- *Taught core course on video game design and programming for master students.*

Senior Research Associate

GETLab, Cyprus University of Technology (January 2021 – Present)

- *Worked in the Research Group led by Principal Investigator Prof. Dr. med. Sebastian Walther.*
- *Designed and co-lead a research project on nonverbal communication and apraxia in Schizophrenia using VR.*

Research Fellow

CYENS Centre of Excellence, Nicosia, Cyprus (September 2020 – September 2021)

- *Worked in the VR for Well-Being Research Group with Principal Investigator Dr. Despina Michael-Grigoriou.*
- *Designed and co-lead research projects on the impact of VR on behaviour and cognition.*

Postdoctoral Researcher

Event-Lab, Institute of Neurosciences, University of Barcelona, Spain (May 2017 – July 2022)

- *Worked in 5-year ERC Project: Moments in Time in Immersive Virtual Environments (MoTIVE), ERC Advanced Grant (https://doi.org/10.3030/742989). Principal Investigator, Prof. Mel Slater.*
- *Designed and conducted research studies in VR and published the findings in high-impact peer-reviewed journals.*
- *Participated in writing grant proposals for research funding.*

Research Assistant

Event-Lab, Institute of Neurosciences, University of Barcelona, Spain (January 2011 – April 2017)

- *Worked in 2-year Project: Beinstein: The Influence of Virtual Embodiment on Intelligence (PSI2014-56301-R Ministerio de Economía, Industria y Competitividad of Spain). Principal Investigator, Prof. Mel Slater.*
- *Worked in multi-year ICT Project: VERE – Virtual Embodiment and Robotic Re-Embodiment (https://cordis.europa.eu/project/id/257695). Principal Investigator, Prof. Mel Slater.*
- *Designed and conducted research studies in VR, published in high-impact peer-reviewed journals and presented at international conferences.*
- *Supervised master students during their practicum.*

Research Assistant

University College London (UCL), London, UK (May 2010 – Sept 2010)

- *Worked in Project: The exploitation of immersive virtual reality for the study of moral judgements by Leverhulme Trust (https://www.leverhulme.ac.uk/research-project-grants-2009). Principal Investigators, Dr. Sylvia Xueni Pan, Prof. Mel Slater.*
- *Designed and conducted a research study on the role of emotions in moral behaviour.*
- *Presented the results at international conference.*

Teaching Experience

New York University (NYU) Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates

Course Leader, IM-UH 2516 Virtual Reality and Applications

Major Interactive Media (Fall 2023, Fall 2024)

- *Developed and taught a course on virtual reality for undergraduate students, with a focus on both the technical development and research methodologies.*
- *Integrated academic and industry insights and guest speakers, allowing students to engage with current trends in the virtual reality sector.*
- *Mentored students through individual projects and provided feedback on VR application prototypes.*
- *Guided students in preparing their classroom projects for submission to international conferences for undergraduate research.*

Course Leader, IM-UH 2320 Games and Play

Major Interactive Media (Fall 2022, Spring 2023, Spring 2024, Spring 2025)

- *Taught a course on game design and development for undergraduate students, with a focus on both digital and non-digital games.*
- *Covered topics such as game mechanics, narrative design, and playtesting, incorporating both theory and practical applications.*
- *Integrated industry insights and guest speakers, as well as visits to industry partners allowing students to engage with current trends in the gaming industry.*
- *Mentored students through individual and team projects and provided feedback on game prototypes.*

Course Leader, IM-UH 1011 Communications Lab

Major Interactive Media (Fall 2022, Spring 2023, Spring 2024, Spring 2025)

- *Taught a production-based course that surveys various technologies including web development, sound, 2D design, digital imaging, video, effects and animation.*
- *Mentored students through individual projects and team projects.*

Main Instructor, IM-UH 4001 Capstone Project

Major Interactive Media (Spring 2023, Fall 2023, Spring 2024, Fall 2024, Spring 2025)

- *Advised and guided students in Interactive Media in selecting and developing their project topics.*
- *Provided academic and research support, monitored progress, and assessed the final outcomes.*

Main Instructor, CS-UH 4001 Capstone Project

Major Computer Science (Fall 2023, Spring 2024, Fall 2024)

- *Advised and guided students in Computer Science in selecting and developing their project topics.*
- *Provided academic and research support, monitored progress, and assessed the final outcomes.*

Universitat Oberta de Catalunya (UOC) Barcelona, Spain

Course Instructor, M7.458 Videogame programming in Unity3D

MSc in Video Game Design and Programming (Spring 2021, Spring 2022)

- *Delivered course on game development for master students, with a focus on digital games using the Unity3D engine.*
- *Provided academic support, monitored progress, and assessed the final outcomes.*

The London School of Economics and Political Science (LSE) London, UK

Guest Lecturer, Virtual Reality in Psychology

Executive MSc Behavioural Science (June 2021, June 2022)

Universitat Pompeu Fabra Barcelona, Spain

Seminar Lecturer, Experimental research in virtual reality

MSc in Brain and Cognition, Department of Information and Communication Technologies (Fall 2020)

Universitat de Barcelona Barcelona, Spain

Seminar Lecturer, Experimental research in virtual reality – theory and technology

MSc Interactive Physiology, Faculty of Biology (Fall 2014, 2015)

Publications

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

Social facilitation within immersive virtual reality enhances perseverance in stroke rehabilitation training
Hadjipanayi C., Sokratous D., Kyrlitsias C., Banakou D., Michael-Grigoriou D. (2025). *Frontiers in Virtual Reality, 6:1581240. doi: 10.3389/frvir.2025.1581240*
(Impact Factor: 3.2, Q1), [Citations: (excluding self-citations)]

Multisensory experiences of affective touch in virtual reality enhance engagement, body ownership, pleasantness, and arousal modulation
Sun W., Banakou D., Świdrak J., Valori I., Slater M., Fairhurst M.T.(2024). *Virtual Reality 28, 162.doi:10.1007/s10055-024-01056-2.*
(Impact Factor: 4.4, Q1), [Citations: 4 (excluding self-citations)]

Development of a Modular Adjustable Wearable Haptic Device for XR Applications
Najm, A., Banakou, D., Michael-Grigoriou, D. (2024). *Virtual Worlds, 3, 436-458. doi:10.3390/virtualworlds3040024.*
(Impact Factor: N/A), [Citations: 4 (excluding self-citations)]

Virtual reality exergames for enhancing engagement in stroke rehabilitation: A narrative review
Hadjipanayi C., Banakou D., Michael-Grigoriou D.(2024). *Heliyon, 10:18, e37581. doi: 10.1016/j.heliyon.2024.e37581.*
(Impact Factor: 3.4, Q1), [Citations: 13 (excluding self-citations)]

Desensitizing Anxiety Through Imperceptible Change: Feasibility Study on a Paradigm for Single-Session Exposure Therapy for Fear of Public Speaking
Banakou D., Johnston T., Beacco A., Senel G., Slater M. (2024). *JMIR Formative Research 2024;8:e52212. doi: 10.2196/52212.*

(Impact Factor: 2.0, Q2), *[Citations: 4 (excluding self-citations)]*

Cultivating empathy through narratives in virtual reality: a review
Hadjipanayi C., Christofi M., Banakou D., Michael-Grigoriou D. (2024). *Personal and Ubiquitous Computing, 28, 507–519. doi:10.1007/s00779-024-01812-w.*
(Impact Factor: 3.41, Q1), [Citations: 12 (excluding self-citations)]

Haptic feedback in a virtual crowd scenario improves the emotional response
Venkatesan R.K., Banakou D., Slater M., Manivannan M. (2023). *Frontiers in Virtual Reality – Haptics, 4:1242587. doi:10.3389/frvir.2023.1242587.*
(Impact Factor: 3.86, Q2), [Citations: 20 (excluding self-citations)]

A comparison of two methods for moving through a virtual environment: walking in place and interactive redirected walking
Banakou D., Slater M. (2023). *Frontiers in Virtual Reality – Virtual Reality and Human Behaviour, 4:1294539. doi:10.3389/frvir.2023.1294539.*
(Impact Factor: 3.86, Q2), [Citations: 6 (excluding self-citations)]

Using virtual reality to assess gesture performance deficits in schizophrenia patients
Pavlidou A., Gorisse G., Banakou D., Walther S. (2023). *Frontiers in Psychiatry, 14:1191601. doi:10.3389/fpsyt.2023.1191601.*
(Impact Factor: 4.52, Q1), [Citations: 8 (excluding self-citations)]

Art as therapy in virtual reality: A scoping review
Hadjipanayi C., Banakou D., Michael-Grigoriou D. (2023). *Frontiers in Virtual Reality, 4:1065863. doi: 10.3389/frvir.2023.1065863.*
(Impact Factor: 3.86, Q2), [Citations: 30 (excluding self-citations)]

The sentiment of a virtual rock concert
Slater, M., Cabriera, C., Senel, G. Banakou D., Beacco A., Oliva R., Gallego J. (2023). *Virtual Reality 27, 651–675. doi:10.1007/s10055-022-00685-9.*
(Impact Factor: 4.2, Q1), [Citations: 30 (excluding self-citations)]

A Separate Reality: An Update on Place Illusion and Plausibility in Virtual Reality
Slater M., Banakou D., Beacco A., Gallego J., Macia-Varela, R Oliva M. (2022). *Frontiers in Virtual Reality 3:914392. doi:10.3389/frvir.2022.914392.*
(Impact Factor: 3.86, Q2), [Citations: 240 (excluding self-citations)]

Self-observation of a virtual body-double engaged in social interaction reduces persecutory thoughts
Gorisse, G., Senel, G., Banakou, D., Beacco, A., Ramon, O., Freeman, D., Slater, M. (2021). *Scientific Reports, 11, 23923. doi:10.1038/s41598-021-03373-x.*
(Impact Factor: 4.6, Q1), [Citations: 18 (excluding self-citations)]

The Golden Rule as a Paradigm for Fostering Prosocial Behavior with Virtual Reality
Slater M., Banakou D. (2021). *Current Directions in Psychological Science. 30(6), 503-509. doi:10.1177/09637214211046954.*
(Impact Factor: 3.03, Q1), [Citations: 22 (excluding self-citations)])

The Influence of Embodiment as a Cartoon Character on Public Speaking Anxiety
Bellido Rivas, A.I., Navarro, X., Banakou, D., Oliva, R., Orvalho, V., Slater, M. (2021). *Frontiers in Virtual Reality, 2:695673. doi: 10.3389/frvir.2021.695673*
(Impact Factor: 3.86, Q2), [Citations: 20 (excluding self-citations)]

Evaluating participant responses to a virtual reality experience using reinforcement learning
Llobera, J., Beacco, A., Oliva, R., Şenel, G., Banakou, D., Slater, M. (2021). *Royal Society Open Science, 8: 210537. doi:10.1098/rsos.210537.*

(Impact Factor: 2.9, Q1), [Citations: 15 (excluding self-citations)]

Virtual body ownership and its consequences for implicit racial bias are dependent on social context
Banakou D., Beacco A., Neyret S., Blasco-Oliver M., Seinfeld S., Slater M. (2020). *Royal Society Open Science, 7:201848. doi: 10.1098/rsos.201848.*
(Impact Factor: 2.9, Q1), [Citations: 100 (excluding self-citations)]

The Rocketbox Library and the Utility of Freely Available Rigged Avatars
Gonzalez-Franco, M., Ofek, E., Pan, Y., Antley, A., Steed, A., Spanlang, B., Maselli, A., Banakou, D., Pelechano, N., Orts-Escolano, S., Orvalho, V., Trutoiu, L., Wojcik, M., Sanchez-Vives, M.V., Bailenson, J., Slater, M., Lanier, J. (2020). *Frontiers in Virtual Reality.* 1:561558*. doi: 10.3389/frvir.2020.561558.*
(Impact Factor: 3.86, Q2), [Citations: 133 (excluding self-citations)]

Exploring the Effect of Cooperation in Reducing Implicit Racial Bias and Its Relationship With Dispositional Empathy and Political Attitudes
Patané, I., Lelgouarch, A., Banakou, D., Verdelet, G., Desoche, C., Koun, E., Salemme, R., Slater, M., Farnè, A. (2020). *Frontiers in Psychology,* 11:510787*. doi: 10.3389/fpsyg.2020.510787.*
(Impact Factor: 2.6, Q2), [Citations: 50 (excluding self-citations)]

Social Conformity in Immersive Virtual Environments: The Impact of Agents' Gaze Behavior
Kyrlitsias, C., Michael-Grigoriou, D., Banakou, D., Christofi, M. (2020). *Frontiers in Psychology,* 11:2254. *doi: 10.3389/fpsyg.2020.02254.*
(Impact Factor: 2.6, Q2), [Citations: 20 (excluding self-citations)]

A Virtual Tour of a Hardly Accessible Archaeological Site: The Effect of Immersive Virtual Reality on User Experience, Learning and Attitude Change
Kyrlitsias, C., Christofi, M., Michael-Grigoriou, D., Banakou, D., Ioannou, A. (2020). *Frontiers in Computer Science,* 2:23. *doi: 10.3389/fcomp.2020.00023.*
(Impact Factor: 2.76, Q2), [Citations: 40 (excluding self-citations)]

A mechanistic account of bodily resonance and implicit bias
Bedder, R.L., Bush, D., Banakou, D., Peck, T., Slater, M., Burgess, N. (2019). Cognition 184, 1-10. doi: 10.1016/j.cognition.2018.11.010.
(Impact Factor: 3.34, Q1), [Citations: 45 (excluding self-citations)]

Virtually Being Einstein Results in an Improvement in Cognitive Task Performance and a Decrease in Age Bias
Banakou, D., Kishore S., Slater M. (2018). *Frontiers in Psychology, 9(917). doi: 10.3389/fpsyg.2018.00917.*
(Impact Factor: 3.8, Q1), [Citations: 250 (excluding self-citations)]

Reducing risk and improving maternal perspective-taking and empathy using virtual embodiment
Hamilton-Giachritsis, C., Banakou, D., Quiroga, M.G., Giachritsis C., Slater, M. (2018). *Scientific Reports, 8(1). doi: 10.1038/s41598-018-21036-2.*
(Impact Factor: 4.6, Q1), [Citations: 85 (excluding self-citations)]

Embodiment in a virtual body that speaks produces agency over the speaking but does not necessarily influence subsequent real speaking
Banakou, D., & Slater, M. (2017). *Scientific Reports, 7(1). doi: 10.1038/s41598-017-14620-5.*
(Impact Factor: 4.6, Q1), [Citations: 32 (excluding self-citations)]

Embodiment in a Child-Like Talking Virtual Body Influences Object Size Perception, Self-Identification, and Subsequent Real Speaking
Tajadura-Jiménez, A., Banakou, D., Bianchi-Berthouze, N., Slater, M. (2017). *Scientific Reports, 7, 9637 (2017). doi: 10.1038/s41598-017-09497-3.*
(Impact Factor: 4.6, Q1), [Citations: 130 (excluding self-citations)]

Embodiment of White People in a Black Virtual Body Leads to a Sustained Reduction in their Implicit Racial Bias
Banakou D., Parasuram D. H., & Slater M. (2016). *Frontiers in Human Neuroscience*, *10 (601). doi: 10.3389/fnhum.2016.00601.*
(Impact Factor: 2.9, Q2), [Citations: 363 (excluding self-citations)]

Body ownership causes illusory self-attribution of speaking and influences subsequent real speaking
Banakou, D., & Slater, M. (2014). *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS), 111, 17678–17683. doi: 10.1073/pnas.1414936111.*
(Impact Factor: 11.1, Q1), [Citations: 162 (excluding self-citations)]

Illusory ownership of a virtual child body causes overestimation of object sizes and implicit attitude changes
Banakou, D., Groten, R. & Slater M. (2013). *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS), 1 (6), 12846–12851. Doi: 10.1073/pnas.130677911.*
(Impact Factor: 11.1, Q1), [Citations: 620 (excluding self-citations)]

Conference papers

Adaptive Virtual Reality Meditation for Adults with ADHD
Zhagufarova, A., Banakou, D., Salam, H. (2026). In: Brooks, A.L., Banakou, D., Ceperkovic, S. (eds) ArtsIT, Interactivity and Game Creation. ArtsIT 2024. Lecture Notes of the Institute for Computer Sciences, Social Informatics and Telecommunications Engineering, vol 651. Springer, Cham. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-97257-7

Tapping into Touch Preferences and Individual Behaviours: Assessing and Improving the HandsOn Mobile App
Fairhurst, M.T., Sun, W., Hadjipanayi, C., Michael-Grigoriou, D., Banakou, D. (2026). In: Brooks, A.L., Banakou, D., Ceperkovic, S. (eds) ArtsIT, Interactivity and Game Creation. ArtsIT 2024. Lecture Notes of the Institute for Computer Sciences, Social Informatics and Telecommunications Engineering, vol 651. Springer, Cham. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-97257-7_10

vER: Virtual Human Companionship for Patients in Preoperative Care
Pandhare A., Skulikj D., Lee J., Mikhie P., Banakou D. (2025). *In Proceedings of the 2025 ACM International Conference on Interactive Media Experiences (IMX '25). Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 468–472. https://doi.org/10.1145/3706370.3731639*

The virtual touch toolkit: An interactive media mobile application for promoting well-being through affective and social touch
Najm, A. , Hadjipanayi, C., Michael-Grigoriou, D., Banakou, D., McGlone, F., Fairhurst, M. (2022). *2nd International Conference on Interactive Media, Smart Systems and Emerging Technologies, IMET 2022, Limassol 4 October 2022, 183954, 1-4. doi: 10.1109/IMET54801.2022.9929934.*
[Citations: 7 (excluding self-citations)]

Computer Based Video and Virtual Environments in the Study of the Role of Emotions in Moral Behavior
Pan, X., Banakou, D., Slater, M. (2011). *In: D'Mello, S., Graesser, A., Schuller, B., Martin, JC. (eds) Affective Computing and Intelligent Interaction. ACII 2011. Lecture Notes in Computer Science, vol 6975. Springer, Berlin, Heidelberg. doi: 10.1007/978-3-642-24571-8_6.*
[Citations: 18 (excluding self-citations)]

Avatars' Appearance and Social Behavior in Online Virtual Worlds
Banakou, D., Chorianopoulos, K., Anagnostou, K. (2009). *13th Panhellenic Conference on Informatics, Corfu, Greece, 2009, pp. 207-211, doi: 10.1109/PCI.2009.9.*
[Citations: 115 (excluding self-citations)]

Books Chapters

Virtual Reality in Stroke Rehabilitation and Treatment: Focusing on the Patient's Experience and Needs
Hadjipanayi, C., Banakou, D., Michael-Grigoriou, D. (2025). In: Charalambous, A. (eds) Critical Perspectives on Technological Innovations in Healthcare. Springer, Cham. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-87158-0_7

Editorials and Commentaries

Understanding and improving the "self" using immersive virtual reality
Kishore, S., Lamba, N., Banakou, D., Seinfeld, S. (2024). *Frontiers in Virtual Reality, 5:1500480. doi: 10.3389/frvir.2024.1500480*

Beyond audiovisual: novel multisensory stimulation techniques and their applications
Świdrak, J., Georgiou, O., Banakou, D., Matamala-Gomez, M., Pochwatko, G., Seinfeld, S. (2024). *Frontiers in Virtual Reality, 5:1491854. doi: 10.3389/frvir.2024.1491854.*
[Citations: 2 (excluding self-citations)]

The light and dark sides of virtual reality
Oberdörfer, S., Banakou, D., Bhargava, A. (2023). *Frontiers in Virtual Reality, 4:1200156. doi: 10.3389/frvir.2023.1200156*
[Citations: 4 (excluding self-citations)]

Virtual reality and empathy
Seinfeld, S., Hasler, B.S., Banakou, D., Levy, J. (2022). *Frontiers in Psychology,* 13:1089006. doi: 10.3389/fpsyg.2022.1089006
[Citations: 10 (excluding self-citations)]

Being Somebody Else: The Future of Narrative Storytelling
Banakou, D., Hadjipanayi, C. (2022). *View: Theories & Practices of Visual Culture/Widok: Teorie I Praktyki (33). doi: 10.36854/widok/2022.33.2570*

Neuropsychological and Cognitive-Behavioral Assessment of Neurodegenerative Disease and Rehabilitation Using New Technologies and Virtual Reality
Matamala-Gomez, M., Stasolla, F., Seinfeld, S., Caffò, A.O., Banakou, D., Bottiroli, S. (2021). *Frontiers in Psychology, 12:691909. doi: 10.3389/fpsyg.2021.691909*
[Citations: 11 (excluding self-citations)]

Keynote and Invited Talks

Immersive Technologies in Mental Health and Neurorehabilitation, Centro de estudios Monlau, Barcelona, Spain (online), 10 November 2025 ***(invited speaker).***

Virtual Reality in Mental Health: Advancing Empathy, Rehabilitation, and Assessment in At-Risk Populations, Vumeni Video Education Platform for Doctors, Online, 15 October 2025 ***(invited speaker).***

Symposia XI: Social Interaction as Transdiagnostic Challenge in Psychiatry, 17th World Congress of Biological Psychiatry (WFSBP), Berlin, Germany, 9-12 September 2025 ***(invited speaker).***

Expo Osaka 2025, Virtual Reality to Transform Behavior, Exhibition at UAE Pavillion: Peace, Human Security and Dignity, Osaka, Kansai, Japan, 8-12 August 2025 ***(keynote speaker)***.

Embodied interactions in VR for Promoting Social Inclusion, HAPCOR Summer School, TU Dresden, Germany, 4-5 September 2024 ***(invited speaker)***.

How Artificial Character Embodiment shapes user behaviour in multi-modal interactions Workshop, 25th International Conference on Multimodal Interaction, Paris, France, 13 October 2023 ***(keynote speaker)***.

The Golden Rule Embodiment Principle, CYENS Center of Excellence, Limassol, Cyprus, 16 May 2023 ***(invited speaker)***.

Enhancing Prosocial Behavior in VR, Würtual Reality XR-Meeting, Würzburg, Germany, 11 April 2023 ***(keynote speaker)***.

Embodiment for a Kinder Society, The Czech Transformative Tech Community, Deloitte, RedButton Edu and pAIoneers, Czech Republic (Online), 16 June 2022 ***(keynote speaker)***.

VR in Healthcare and Rehabilitation , Universitäre Psychiatrische Dienste Bern, Bern, Switzerland, 5 June 2022 ***(invited speaker)***.

Changing Behaviours in Immersive Virtual Reality, The London School of Economics and Political Science, London (Online), UK, 4 May 2022 ***(invited speaker)***.

From Embodiment to Changes in Attitudes, Cognition, and Prosocial Behaviour, Centre for the Analysis of Motion, Entertainment Research and Applications (CAMERA), Bath (Online), UK, 19 Jan 2022 ***(invited speaker)***.

How to Overcome the Body, VACZINE ART Symposium, Düsseldorf (Online), Germany, 4 Jul 2021 ***(keynote speaker)***.

Can IVR change empathy? University of Milano-Bicocca, Milan (Online), Italy, 19 Mar 2021 ***(invited speaker)***.

Immersive virtual reality to reduce racial bias and improve parenting, Middlesex University Dubai Research Seminar Series, Dubai, UAE, Jan 2020 ***(invited speaker)***.

Immersive Virtual Reality: Technology, Concepts, and Multisensory Integration, The Active Self Autumn School I, Herrsching, Germany, Oct 2019 ***(invited speaker)***.

Being Somebody Else: The Future of Narrative Storytelling, Filmteractive 2019, Lodz, Poland, Oct 2019 ***(keynote speaker)***.

Virtual Body Representation Can Change the Self, Integrative Science Symposium: How Changing Our Bodies changes Our Selves, 3rd Biennial International Convention of Psychological Science, Paris, France, Mar 2019 ***(keynote speaker)***.

Becoming Someone Else through Virtual Reality: Methods and Research, Latvian Digital Forum 'Datos balstīta nācija', Cēsis, Latvia, Oct 2018 ***(keynote speaker)***.

Virtual Embodiment for Character-based Gaming: The Impact on Perception, Attitudes, and Behaviour, PhD Days, Marseille, France, Dec 2017 ***(keynote speaker)***.

Behavioural and Perceptual Embodiment in Immersive Virtual Reality, Cyprus University of Technology, Limassol, Cyprus, Nov 2015 ***(invited speaker)***.

Panels & Short Presentations

VR Embodiment for Social Change, XRGroup Graduate School of Engineering Science, University of Osaka, Kansai, Japan, 7 August 2025.

MoTIVE - Moments in Time in Immersive Virtual Environments, IEEE VR VHCIE workshop, Te Pae (Online), New Zealand, 12 Mar 2022.

Opportunities and Challenges in Harnessing VR Technology for Bias Mitigation, IEEE VR 2021, Lisbon, Virtual, 27 Mar - 3 Apr 2021.

Challenging Tech's Path Forward - Avatars for Virtual Reality, SXSW PanelPicker 2021, Online, 16-20 Mar 2021.

Avatars for AI and VR, IEEE AIVR 2020 Special Session Panel, Online, Dec 2020.

Walking in Groups in Immersive Virtual Reality: Temporal coupling during in-group and out-group interactions, Social Bridges e-Conference, Munich, Germany, Nov 2020.

Implicit Racial Bias in Affective Social Contexts In IVR, Moments in Time in Immersive Virtual Environments (MoTIVE) Symposium, Barcelona, Spain, Jan 2020.

Virtual Embodiment: Methods & Research, Central Institute of Mental health, Mannheim, Germany, Sept 2018.

Virtually being Einstein results in an improvement in cognitive ability and a decrease in age bias, 11th FENS Forum of Neuroscience, Berlin, Germany, Jul 2018.

Virtual Embodiment: Perception, Attitudes, and Behaviour, University of Plymouth Seminar Days, Plymouth, UK, Oct 2017.

Psychological and Perceptual Embodiment in IVR – Two paradigms, XXVIII International Congress of the Spanish Society for Comparative Psychology, Barcelona, Spain, Sept 2016.

The Influence of Body Representation on Behaviour and Cognition – An Extensive Implicit Racial Bias Study, Interdisciplinary Summer School on Social Cognition: From interactions to intersubjectivity, Aegina, Greece, Jun 2016.

The sense of psychological and perceptual embodiment in Immersive Virtual Reality systems, 1st IR3C PhD Symposium, Barcelona, Spain, Sept 2015.

Embodied agency causes illusory self-attribution of speaking and influences subsequent real speaking, 2nd VERE PhD Symposium, Barcelona, Spain, Oct 2014.

Computer Based Video and Virtual Environments in the Study of the Role of Emotions in Moral Behavior, Fourth International Conference, ACII 2011, Memphis, TN, USA, Oct 2011.

Media Coverage & Public Engagement

NHK Japan Broadcasting Corporation
"Frontiers – The World is Made of Illusions" by Joe Odagiri and Yu Aoi – Featured research in Japanese documentary series exploring virtual reality's role in ownership illusions and behavioural changes. (October 31, 2024)

Popular Mechanics
"The VR 'Proteus Effect' Explained" by Sarah Wells – Insights provided on how virtual avatars can influence user behaviour and identity. (October 16, 2023)

Epsiloon Magazine *(printed version only)*
"Effect Proteus – Le Pouvoir des Avatars" by Muriel Valin – Featured research in French article exploring the role of avatars in behavioural change. (October 9, 2023)

SpartieLab Podcast
"E9 The Proteus Effect, Bias and Body Ownership" by Rabindra (Robby) Ratan – Podcast interview discussing embodiment in VR. (April 14, 2021)

APS Observer
"Mind Over Body" by Alexandra Michel – Article highlighting research on body ownership illusions in virtual reality. (March 24, 2020)

ERT (Greek National Television)
"Virtual reality and the sense of embodiment" by Eve Tsirigotaki – Greek article featured in a segment on the psychological effects of virtual reality. (November 21, 2019)

The Psychologist
"Shattering the self" – Discussed the contradictory nature of the self in virtual environments. (July 1, 2019)

BBC Click
"Virtual lives: Could VR change how we think of others?" – Featured in a segment discussing the impact of virtual reality on empathy and social perception. (October 11, 2018)

The New Yorker
"Are we already living in virtual reality?" by Joshua Rothman – Contribution to an article exploring the philosophical implications of immersive virtual environments. (March 26, 2018)

"Bias" Documentary
Directed by Robin Hauser – Featured in a documentary film exploring implicit biases and virtual reality's role in addressing them. (2018)

Big Think
"People who embody Albert Einstein in VR perform better on cognitive tasks" by Stephen Johnson – Coverage of studies showing cognitive enhancement through virtual embodiment. (July 11, 2018)

Advocator
"A Study Showed Better Results on Cognitive Tasks for People Who Embody Albert Einstein in VR" by Brad Bennett. (July 13, 2018)

Science Daily
"Seeing yourself as Einstein may change the way you think" – Coverage of findings on virtual embodiment and cognitive performance. (July 9, 2018)

Mail Online
"People who see themselves as Albert Einstein suddenly think they are smarter: Being in the body of someone highly intelligent changes how people view their own intellect" by Alexandra Thompson – Coverage of findings on virtual embodiment and cognitive performance. (July 9, 2018)

El Confidencial
"Dentro del laboratorio que te convierte en víctima de maltrato, Freud, un bebé o Lenin" by Ángel Villarino – Spanish article featuring research on immersive virtual reality experiences. (May 21, 2018)

PNAS
"Virtual reality therapy set for a real renaissance by" M. Mitchell Waldrop – Coverage on VR research on its effectiveness in treating an array of mental ailments. (September 26, 2017)

The New Yorker
"This is your avatar speaking" by Nicola Twilley – Interviewed about research on virtual embodiment and its effects on self-perception. (February 20, 2015)

Voices of VR Podcast
"Research into the Virtual Body Ownership Illusion" by Kent Bye – Podcast interview discussing the nuances of body ownership in virtual environments. (November 25, 2015)

BBC Science

"Can virtual reality be used to tackle racism?" by Melissa Hogenboom – Contribution to a science article covering how VR can be used to tackle racism. (November 28, 2013)

Discover Magazine
"Illusion Makes People Speak with the Voice of Their Avatar" by Elizabeth Preston – Research featured on the impact of virtual avatars on speech patterns. (November 26, 2014)

Supervision & Academic Engagement

PhD Supervision and Mentorship

- ***Co-supervisor***, PhD Candidate: Christos Hadjipanayi, Department of Multimedia and Graphic Arts, Cyprus University of Technology (2022–Ongoing).
  Topic*: Virtual reality with social co-presence for rehabilitation.*
- ***Co-supervisor***, PhD Candidate: Ali Najm, Department of Multimedia and Graphic Arts, Cyprus University of Technology (2022–Ongoing).
  Topic*: Enhancing the Sense of embodiment in VR.*
- ***Advisor Committee****,* PhD Candidate: Matilde Tassinari, Faculty of Social Sciences, University of Helsinki, Finland (2022–2024).
  Topic: *Navigating Prejudice in Virtual Reality: Direct, Indirect, and Secondary Transfer Effects of Positive and Negative Intergroup Contact in VR.*
- ***Mentor,*** PhD Candidate: Lisa Izzouzi, University College London, UK (2022–2023).
  Topic: *Virtual Emerging Leadership.*

MSc/Master's Supervision and Mentorship

- ***Co-supervisor,*** Lucile Bottein, MSc Cognitive Neuroscience, University College London, UK. Principal Supervisor: Dr. Aneesha Singh (2022-2023).
  Topic*: Modelling Changes in Implicit Racial Bias after an Immersive Virtual Reality Experience*
- ***Mentor,*** Rachel Bedder, Brain and Mind Sciences MSc, University College London, UK. Principal Supervisor: Dr. Neil Burgess and Dr. Dan Bush (2017-2018).
  Topic*: Asymmetries Between Gains and Losses in Mood and Decision Making.*

Undergraduate Supervision & Mentoring

- ***Supervisor*****,** 9 undergraduate/capstone projects at the Interactive Media department, New York University (NYU) Abu Dhabi, UAE (2022-2025).
- ***Supervisor,*** *2* undergraduate students in at the Computer Science department, New York University (NYU) Abu Dhabi, UAE (2023-2025).
- ***Co-Supervisor,*** 5 undergraduate students in at the Computer Science department, New York University (NYU) Abu Dhabi, UAE (2023-2025).
- ***Mentor****,* 8 RAs in research projects at the Interactive Media, Computer Science, Political Science, and Psychology departments, New York University (NYU) Abu Dhabi, UAE (2023-2025);

PhD Committees

- ***Thesis Examiner****,* PhD Dissertation for Dr. Cory A. Logston, Media Psychology, Fielding Graduate University, California, USA (January 2024). Topic: *The effects of historical empathy and transformative learning on implicit bias in a virtual reality experience.*
- ***Thesis Examiner****,* PhD Dissertation for Dr. Brett Parton, School of Applied Psychology, Griffith University, Australia (August 2024). Topic: *An Investigation of Key Factors in the Viability and Effectiveness of Virtual Reality Exposure Therapy for the Fear of Public Speaking.*

- ***Thesis Defense Secretary***, PhD Dissertation for Dr. Judith Guadalupe Ley Flores, Science and Information Technology, Universidad Carlos III Madrid, Spain (September 2022). Topic: *Using movement sonification to alter body perception and promote physical activity in physically inactive.*
- ***Thesis Defense Opponent***, PhD Dissertation for Dr. Mila Bujić, of Information Technology and Communication Sciences. Tampere University, Finland (July 2021). Topic: *Immersive Persuasiveness: Investigating media effects of 360-degree immersive journalism*.
- ***Thesis Examiner***, BIS/MIS PhD Dissertation for Dr. Wanxian Zeng, Research School of Management at The Australian National University, Australia (June 2021). Topic: *Adding Dimension to Content: Immersive Virtual Reality and Presence for e-Commerce*.
- ***Thesis Defense Opponent***, PhD Dissertation for Dr. Marina Scattolin, Psychology & Social Neuroscience Sapienza University, Italy (April 2021). Topic: *How the sense of body ownership shapes honesty: Evidence from behavioural, clinical and immersive virtual reality studies.*

Awards & Grants

Tamkeen Research Grant UAE, 2024.

- Amount: $15000
- Role: Principal Investigator
- Developing VR-based experiences to study human responses in economic games.

NYU Faculty Advancement Grant UAE, 2024.

- Amount: $4500
- Awarded active member of the NYU Abu Dhabi Research Community to foster the development of my individual research endeavours and contribute to enhancing my academic career.

Tamkeen Research Grant UAE, 2023.

- Amount: $15000
- Role: Principal Investigator
- Developing a VR-based intervention in art and rehabilitation.

NYUAD Institute Events Sponsorship UAE, 2023.

- Amount: $14000
- Awarded for the organization of public events/workshops/conferences hosted at NYU Abu Dhabi.

Tamkeen Research Grant UAE, 2022.

- Amount: $15000
- Role: Principal Investigator
- Developing VR-based experiences to study implicit biases.

FENS-IBRO/PERC Travel Grant Berlin, 2018.
SIGGRAPH European Contest Grant IST Austria, 2016.
Eurolife Grant - Summer School "Emotions" Innsbruck, 2015.
"Best Young Researcher" Award University of Barcelona, 2015.
FI-DGR Grant for universities and research centres for the recruitment of new research personnel Spain, 2014.
Ionian University Award of Program in Informatics Greece, 2009.
IKY 2009 (Greek State Scholarships Foundation) Award & Scholarship Greece, 2008.
IKY 2008 (Greek State Scholarships Foundation) Award & Scholarship Greece, 2007.
IKY 2007 (Greek State Scholarships Foundation) Award & Scholarship Greece, 2006.

Professional Service

Memberships

- *Professional Member,* Association for Computing Machinery (ACM) (2024–Present).
- *Individual Member*, EuroXR Association (2024–Present).
- *Full Member (by nomination only)*, Sigma Xi The Scientific Research Honor Society (2024–Present). Nominated by Jamie L. Vernon, PhD, Executive Director and CEO Sigma Xi for showing noteworthy achievement as an original investigator in a field of pure or applied science.
- *Fellow Recognition,* European Alliance for Innovation (2024–Present). Honoured for exceptional contributions and leadership in engineering and technology and significantly advancing the field, impacting both academia and industry internationally.

Editorial Boards

- *Assistant Specialty Chief Editor,* Frontiers in Virtual Reality (1 year).
  Topics: Virtual Reality and Behaviour.
- *Academic Editor*, PLOS One (4 years).
  Topics: Psychology - Cognitive psychology, Neuroscience - Behavioral and cognitive, Computer and information sciences - Human-Computer interactions.
- *Guest Associate Editor,* Frontiers in Psychology (3 years).
  Topics: Personality and Social Psychology, Neuropsychology.
- *Review Editor,* Frontiers in Virtual Reality (2 years).
  Topics: Virtual Reality and Behaviour.
- *Review Editor,* Frontiers in Psychology (3 years).
  Topics: Consciousness Research.
- *Research Topics Editor,* Frontiers in Virtual Reality.
  Topic: Beyond audiovisual: novel multisensory stimulation techniques and their applications (2024).
  Topic: Understanding and Improving the 'Self' Using Immersive Virtual Reality (2024).
  Topic: Editors Showcase: Embodiment in Virtual Reality (2023).
  Topic: The Light and Dark Sides of Virtual Reality (2023).
  Topic: VR/AR to Support Diversity, Equality, and Inclusion (2022).
- *Research Topics Editor,* Frontiers in Psychology.
  Topic: Virtual Reality and Empathy (2022).
  Topic: Social BRIDGES: Society, Psychology and Behavior During and Post COVID-19 (2021).
  Topic: Neuropsychological and Cognitive-Behavioral Assessment of Neurodegenerative Disease and Rehabilitation Using New Technologies and Virtual Reality (2021).
- *Research Topics Editor,* Frontiers in Robotics and AI.
  Topic: Virtual and Robotic Embodiment – From Neuroscience to Virtual Reality and Robotics (2020).
- *Research Topics Editor,* MDPI Virtual Worlds.
  Topic: New Insights on Haptics and Human–Computer Interaction Systems in Virtual Reality (2024).

Peer Review Journals

- *Reviewer*, Frontiers in Psychology (8 years).
  Reviewer, Frontiers in Robotics and AI (4 years).
- *Reviewer*, Frontiers in Virtual Reality (3 years).
- *Reviewer*, Frontiers in Human Neuroscience (2 years).
- *Reviewer*, PLOS One (6 years).
- *Reviewer*, Scientific Reports – Nature (4 years).
- *Reviewer*, Springer Nature – Virtual Reality (VIRE) (5 years).
- *Reviewer*, Elsevier – The Arts in Psychotherapy (1 year).
- *Reviewer*, Elsevier – Computers in Human Behavior Reports (3 years).
- *Reviewer*, Sage Journals – Digital Health (2 years).

- ***Reviewer***, MDPI – Journal of Clinical Medicine (2 years).

Conference Committees and Roles

General Chair, Program Chair, Local Chair, EAI ArtsIT 2024, 13th International Conference on ArtsIT, Interactivity, and Game Creation, NYU Abu Dhabi, UAE (Nov 2024).

- *Coordinated with committee chairs and oversaw event organization and logistical arrangements.*
- *Organized the structure of the conference program, including sessions, workshops, tutorials, and keynotes.*
- *Oversaw the production of the conference proceedings and ensured the quality and consistency of the content in the proceedings.*
- *Chaired sessions during the conference.*

General Chair, 2nd Virtual Embodiment and Robotic Re-Embodiment (VERE) PhD Symposium, Barcelona, Spain (2014).

- *Coordinated with committee chairs and oversaw event organization. Organized the structure of the conference program, including scheduling sessions, workshops, tutorials, and keynote addresses.*
- *Oversaw logistical arrangements to support the content and local organization.*
- *Chaired sessions during the conference.*

General Co-Chair, Organizing Committee, 1st Institute for Brain, Cognition and Behavior (IR3C) PhD Symposium, Barcelona, Spain (Oct 2015).

- *Coordinated with committee chairs and oversaw event organization. Oversaw logistical arrangements to support the content and local organization.*
- *Chaired sessions during the conference.*

Applications Track Co-Chair, 21st EuroXR 2024 International Conference, Athens, Greece (Nov 2024).

- *Coordinated with program chairs and oversaw track organization. Reviewed and selected papers related to applications in XR.*
- *Chaired session during the conference.*

Demo Track Co-Chair, ICAT-EGVE 2018, 28th International Conference on Artificial Reality and Telexistence Limassol, Cyprus (Nov 2018).

- *Coordinated with program chairs and oversaw track organization.*
- *Chaired session during the conference.*

Program Committee Member, VRST 2025, 31st *ACM Symposium on Virtual Reality Software and Technology, Christchurch, New Zealand (Nov 2025).*

- Reviewed submitted manuscripts and coordinated with reviewers to ensure the timely evaluation of submitted papers.

Program Committee Member, EAI ArtsIT 2025, 14th International Conference on ArtsIT, Interactivity, and Game Creation, Dubai, UAE (Nov 2025).

- *Collaborated with the conference organizing committee to draft, launch, and promote the CFP.*
- *Oversee the peer review process.*

Program Committee Member, VRST 2023, *29th ACM Symposium on Virtual Reality Software and Technology, Christchurch, New Zealand (Oct 2023).*

- *Reviewed submitted manuscripts and coordinated with reviewers to ensure the timely evaluation of submitted papers.*

Program Committee Member, MELECON 2016, 18th Mediterranean Electrotechnical Conference, Limassol, Cyprus (Apr 2016).

- *Coordinated with program chairs and oversaw track organization. Chaired session during the conference.*

- *Reviewed submitted manuscripts and coordinated with reviewers to ensure the timely evaluation of submitted papers.*

Program Committee Member, *AIVR 2020, 3rd International Conference on Artificial Intelligence & Virtual Reality, Online (Dec 2020).*

- *Reviewed submitted manuscripts and coordinated with reviewers to ensure the timely evaluation of submitted papers.*

Conferences Reviewing Committee

- EAI ArtsIT 2025, 14th International Conference on ArtsIT, Interactivity, and Game Creation, Dubai, UAE (Nov 2025).
- VRST 2025, 31st ACM Symposium on Virtual Reality Software and Technology, Montreal, Canada (Nov 2025).
- ISMAR 2025,24th IEEE International Symposium on Mixed and Augmented Reality, Daejeon, South Korea (Oct 2025).
- CASA 2025, 38th International Conference on Computer Animation and Social Agents, Strasbourg, France (Jun 2025).
- IEEE VR 2025, 32nd IEEE Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces, Saint-Malo, France (Mar 2025).
- CHI 2025, ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, Yokohama, Japan (Apr 2025).
- IEEE VR 2024, 32nd IEEE Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces, Orlando, FL, USA (Mar 2024).
- CHI 2024, ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, Hawaii, USA (May 2024).
- ISMAR 2024, 23rd IEEE International Symposium on Mixed and Augmented Reality, Seattle, USA (Oct 2024).
- MXR 2024, Meaning XR Conference 2024, Stanford/Palo Alto, CA. USA (May 2024).
- VRST 2024, 30th ACM Symposium on Virtual Reality Software and Technology, Tier, Germany (Oct 2024).
- CHI 2023, ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, Hambourg, Germany (Apr 2023).
- IMX 2023, ACM International Conference on Interactive Media Experiences, Nantes, France (May 2023).
- ISMAR 2023, 22nd IEEE International Symposium on Mixed and Augmented Reality, Sydney, Australia (Oct 2023).
- IEEE VR 2023, 30th IEEE Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces, Shanghai, China (Mar 2023).
- IEEE VR 2022, 29th IEEE Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces, Online (Mar 2022).
- CHI 2022, ACM CHI conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, New Orleans, LA, USA (Apr 2022).
- ISEA 2022, 27th International Symposium on Electronic Art, Barcelona, Spain (June 2022).
- VRST 2022, 28th ACM Symposium on Virtual Reality Software and Technology, Online/Tsukuba, Japan (Nov 2022).
- IEEE VR 2021, IEEE Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces, Online (Mar 2021).
- DIS 2021, ACM Designing Interactive Systems Conference, Online (Jul 2021).
- CSCW 2021, 24th ACM Conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing, Online (Oct 2021).
- SAP 2020, ACM Symposium on Applied Perception, Online (Sept 2020).
- CSCW 2020, 23rd ACM Conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing, Virtual (originally Minneapolis, USA) (Oct 2020).
- CHI PLAY 2020, The Annual Symposium on Computer-Human Interaction in Play, Online (Nov 2020).
- IEEE VR 2020, IEEE Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces, Online, Atlanta, USA (Mar 2020).
- IEEE VR 2019, IEEE Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces, Osaka, Japan (Mar 2019).
- VRAIMA 2019, 1st International Workshop on Virtual Reality and Artificial Intelligence in Medical Applications, Valencia, Spain (Jun 2019).
- SAP 2019, ACM Symposium on Applied Perception, Barcelona, Spain (Sept 2019).
- ACII 2019, 8th International Conference on Affective Computing & Intelligent Interaction, Cambridge, UK (Sept 2019).